

stituencies have historically delivered for the Congress and AIUDF. Their alliance in 2021 had helped Congress capture 30 per cent of the vote, compared to the BJP's 33 per cent, yet converted that share into only 29 seats drawn from just 13 of Assam's 35 districts. With Muslim demography squeezed into fewer seats, the already poor vote-to-seat conversion rate is likely to deteriorate further. Without a Congress-AIUDF alliance, the two parties' core vote banks will split.

Meanwhile, the AGP is fielding 13 Muslim candidates, several of them turncoats from the AIUDF. In multi-cornered contests across these constituencies, Muslim votes are primed to fragment, hurting the Congress and its allies.

Four additional forces are working in the BJP's favour: Sarma's personal popularity, his government's visible infrastructure record, an expansive architecture of welfare schemes and sustained polarisation over illegal immigration from Bangladesh. Sarma's popularity is, by any measure, a political phenomenon. Ordinary citizens are drawn to the image of a man who delivers on his promises, an image built across two decades.

Delivery, under his watch this tenure, acquired both speed and scale. The CM runs a near–round-the-clock operation, and is hands-on and detail-obsessed. His day begins at 7 am on the phone with bureaucrats and political aides and often stretches till 3 am, with officials summoned past midnight to clear files. When travelling, directives move over WhatsApp. "He avoids inter-departmental file ping-pong, often calling multiple secretaries to clear coordinated projects in one go," says a bureaucrat. Adds another: "He has a photographic memory and tracks minor details with weekly reviews. That's what drives the speed."

Delivery on Promises

If Sarma's government held transparent recruitment examinations for government jobs, he also delivered over 100,000 government jobs, as promised. In his next term, he vows to double the number of jobs. The road network has expanded, flyovers and bridges have been built in record time, industrial investment, including semiconductor units, has been brought to the state. According to RBI data, Assam is India's fastest growing state, clocking 45 per cent growth between FY20 and FY25, above the national average of 29 per cent.

There are other achievements too. The Sarma government's welfare schemes reach about six–seven million households or around 25 to 30 million people. This means around 75–85 per cent of Assam's 35 million population is covered by at least one scheme. Between 2021 and 2026, the government is estimated to have spent Rs 30,000–Rs 35,000 crore on these schemes.

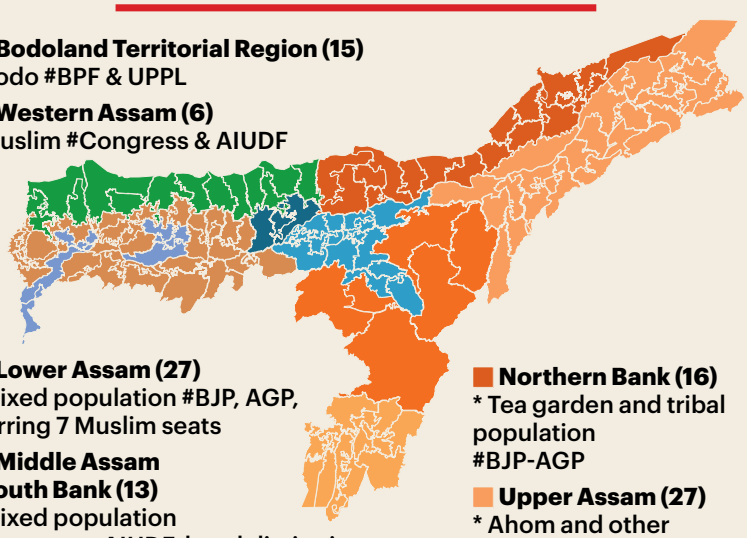
The Congress and BJP manifestos reflect two divergent electoral philosophies—one anchored in performance-led continuity and development, the other in direct welfare guarantees. The BJP's Sankalp Patra, with 31 detailed pledges across 75 pages, include a Rs 5 lakh crore infrastructure push, a Rs 18,000 crore flood-proofing mission, 200,000 government jobs, hikes in the

ANI



PRAYING FOR A MIRACLE
Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi and Assam Congress chief Gaurav Gogoi (second from right) at the Kamakhya temple in Guwahati, Feb.19

THE BATTLE ZONES



Bodoland Territorial Region (15)
*Bodo #BPF & UPPL

Western Assam (6)
*Muslim #Congress & AIUDF

Lower Assam (27)
*Mixed population #BJP, AGP, barring 7 Muslim seats

Middle Assam -South Bank (13)
*Mixed population #Congress, AIUDF, but delimitation will reduce advantage

Middle Assam-North Bank (3)
* Muslim, Nepali, Tea Tribes
Congress, AIUDF

Northern Bank (16)
* Tea garden and tribal population #BJP-AGP

Upper Assam (27)
* Ahom and other indigenous groups #BJP-AGP

Hill districts (6)
* Karbi and Dimasa #BJP

Barak Valley (13)
* Bangla-speaking Hindus and Muslims #BJP

**Swing social groups; no. of seats in ()*
#Dominant party in the past two assembly polls